

July 2024 Quota Protests: Students Rise for Fairness in Bangladesh

The July 2024 protests in Bangladesh started because of a court decision about government job quotas. On June 5, 2024, the High Court said the 2018 order that removed quotas was not legal. This brought back the old rule where 30% of government jobs were saved for children of freedom fighters. Many students and job seekers were upset, as they believed this system was unfair and stopped talented people from getting jobs based on merit. The protest began peacefully on July 1, 2024. It was led by students under the name "Anti-Discrimination Students Movement." They held rallies and sit-ins at universities and public places. On July 7, the protest grew bigger with the "Bangla Blockade," where roads and train stations were blocked in many cities. The students demanded a job system that rewards skill and qualifications, not family background. On July 14, 2024, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina made a speech that angered many protesters. She questioned the goals of the movement and even said that many of the girls protesting were not smart enough to pass job exams. Many people found these words insulting and hurtful. As a result, more people joined the protests, especially young women. Tragedy struck on July 16, 2024, during a clash between police and protesters in Dhaka. Five people died, including a student named Shahriar Khan Anas, who was shot by police in the Chankharpul area. His death shocked the nation and made the protests even stronger. People saw him as a symbol of the fight for justice. After the first deaths, the protests became larger and spread across the country. Police and security forces used real bullets in some places. More than 1,000 people died, and thousands were injured. The government tried to stop the protests by setting curfews, sending in the army, and blocking the internet. But none of these worked. The protests turned into a bigger fight against unfair rule and abuse of power. On July 21, 2024, the Supreme Court made a new decision. It said 93% of government jobs would be based on merit and only 7% would be saved for special groups. Still, many protesters were not satisfied. They wanted government leaders to step down and for the people responsible for violence to be punished. At last, the protests brought big changes. On August 5, 2024, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina resigned and left the country. An interim government was formed, led by Nobel Peace Prize winner Muhammad Yunus. He promised to bring reforms and solve the problems that caused the protests. This victory showed the strength and unity of the people when they stand together for fairness. The July 2024 protests will be remembered as a powerful example of how ordinary people, especially students, can bring big change through courage and determination.

Dr. Muhammad Yunus – Architect of Social Change and Democratic Transition in Bangladesh

Dr. Muhammad Yunus was born on June 28, 1940, in Chittagong, Bangladesh. He is a famous economist and social worker. He is best known for creating the idea of microcredit giving small loans to poor people, especially women, so they can start small businesses and improve their lives. In 1983, he started the Grameen Bank, which helps people in need get loans without needing anything in return. His work has helped reduce poverty around the world. Because of this, he won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2006. He also received other big awards like the Ramon Magsaysay Award in 1984, the Presidential Medal of Freedom in 2009, and the Congressional Gold Medal in 2010. In 2025, TIME magazine named him one of the 100 Most Influential

People for his continued work helping people through business ideas that focus on solving social problems, not just making money. In August 2024, there was political unrest in Bangladesh, and the Prime Minister, Sheikh Hasina, stepped down on August 5. Just a few days later, on August 8, Dr. Yunus was chosen to lead the interim government as Chief Adviser. His job was to bring peace and help the country prepare for fair elections and write a new constitution with help from people in civil society. In March 2025, Dr. Yunus visited China for the first time as the head of the interim government. He stayed from March 26 to 29. During the visit, he met with Chinese President Xi Jinping and spoke at a big international event called the Boao Forum. His main goal was to make the relationship between Bangladesh and China stronger and to bring Chinese investments to Bangladesh. Soon, China's commerce minister is expected to visit Bangladesh with 100 investors to explore business opportunities. Dr. Yunus was recently named one of TIME magazine's 100 Most Influential People in 2025. This shows how much the world respects his efforts to help people through social business. He also took part in giving out the Independence Award 2025 the highest award in Bangladesh to seven important people for their great service to the country.

The Russia-Ukraine Conflict: A Struggle for Sovereignty and Stability

The Russia-Ukraine conflict, which began in 2014 with Russia's annexation of Crimea, escalated into a full-scale war on February 24, 2022, when Russian forces invaded Ukraine from multiple fronts. Russian President Vladimir Putin justified the invasion as a "special military operation" aimed at "demilitarizing and denazifying" Ukraine. Ukraine's military and civilian population mounted a strong resistance, preventing Russia from capturing Kyiv and reclaiming significant territories, including Kharkiv and Kherson, during counteroffensives in late 2022. Despite these efforts, Russia maintains control over approximately 20% of Ukrainian territory as of 2025. The war has resulted in substantial casualties, with estimates indicating nearly 500,000 military personnel killed or wounded and over 10,000 civilian deaths. The conflict has also displaced millions, leading to a significant refugee crisis. Internationally, the invasion has been widely condemned, leading to severe economic sanctions against Russia and substantial military and humanitarian aid to Ukraine. The United States and European Union have been prominent supporters, though political divisions have affected the Economically, the war has disrupted global supply chains, particularly in energy and agriculture, contributing to inflation and food shortages in various regions. As the conflict persists into its third year, diplomatic solutions remain elusive. While some advocate for negotiations to prevent further loss of life, others argue that any compromise may undermine Ukraine's sovereignty and international law. In conclusion, the Russia-Ukraine war continues to have profound implications, not only for the two nations involved but also for global stability and international relations.

Global Warming: A Growing Threat to Our Planet

Global warming refers to the long-term increase in Earth's average surface temperature due to the accumulation of greenhouse gases in the atmosphere. These gases—mainly carbon dioxide (CO₂), methane (CH₄), and nitrous oxide (N₂O)—are largely the result of human activities such as burning fossil fuels, deforestation, and industrial processes. As these gases trap heat from the sun, the Earth's temperature continues to rise, leading to a range of environmental and

societal problems. One of the most alarming effects of global warming is the melting of polar ice caps and glaciers, which causes sea levels to rise. This threatens coastal cities and small island nations, putting millions of people at risk of displacement. Additionally, global warming intensifies weather events, making hurricanes, droughts, floods, and wildfires more frequent and severe. These disasters not only destroy ecosystems but also damage infrastructure and claim human lives. Many animals and plants are having trouble living in the warmer climate. Some may disappear forever because they can't survive the changes. Global warming also affects farming. Crops may not grow well because of too much heat or not enough water, which can cause food shortages in many parts of the world. Countries around the world are trying to fight global warming. They are working together in agreements like the Paris Agreement, where they promise to reduce pollution and protect nature. People can also help by using less energy, planting trees, recycling, and using clean energy like wind or solar power.

Environmental Pollution: A Danger to Our Planet

Environmental pollution is the presence of harmful substances in our surroundings that make the air, water, and land dirty and unsafe. It is one of the biggest problems the world faces today. Pollution is mainly caused by human activities such as factories releasing smoke and chemicals, vehicles producing harmful gases, cutting down trees, and throwing waste into rivers and oceans.

There are different types of pollution—air pollution, water pollution, soil pollution, and noise pollution. Air pollution happens when smoke and harmful gases from factories and vehicles fill the air. This can cause breathing problems and diseases like asthma. Water pollution occurs when people throw garbage, plastic, and chemicals into rivers, lakes, and oceans. This makes the water unsafe for drinking, kills fish and other water animals, and harms people who use that water. Soil pollution happens when harmful chemicals and waste are dumped on the land, making it hard to grow healthy crops. Noise pollution, caused by loud sounds from traffic, machines, and loudspeakers, can lead to hearing problems and stress. Pollution affects all living things. It harms animals, plants, and people. It also contributes to climate change by increasing the amount of greenhouse gases in the air. If we do not take action, pollution will make the Earth a very difficult place to live. To reduce pollution, we need to take steps like using fewer plastic items, recycling waste, planting trees, using clean energy like solar power, and keeping our surroundings clean. Governments, organizations, and individuals must work together to protect the environment. In conclusion, environmental pollution is a serious threat to our health and the planet. Everyone has a role to play in keeping the Earth clean and safe. Small efforts by many people can bring big changes.

Road Accidents in Bangladesh: A Growing Concern

Road accidents are a significant and growing concern in Bangladesh, leading to numerous deaths, injuries, and economic losses each year. In 2024 alone, at least 8,543 people lost their lives, and 12,608 were injured in 6,359 road crashes across the country. Several factors contribute to the high rate of road accidents in Bangladesh. These include reckless driving, risky overtaking, unfit vehicles, unskilled drivers, and the use of mobile phones or headphones while driving. Additionally, poor road conditions and a lack of awareness among road users exacerbate the situation. The economic impact of road accidents is also substantial. In 2024,

road accidents cost Bangladesh over Tk 21,880 crore, highlighting the urgent need for comprehensive measures to improve road safety and reduce economic losses. To address this issue, the Bangladesh government has initiated steps toward enhancing road safety. In January 2024, road safety advocates celebrated the government's call for the development of a new and comprehensive Road Safety Act. This initiative aims to improve enforcement of traffic violations, driver licensing, and vehicle registration systems. In conclusion, road accidents in Bangladesh pose a serious threat to public safety and economic stability. Addressing this issue requires a multifaceted approach, including stricter enforcement of traffic laws, improved road infrastructure, driver education, and public awareness campaigns. By taking these steps, Bangladesh can work towards reducing road accidents and ensuring safer roads for all.

Deforestation and Its Impact on Bangladesh

Deforestation is a serious environmental issue in Bangladesh, with significant consequences for the country's ecosystems, climate, and communities. Over the years, large areas of forest have been cleared for agricultural expansion, urban development, and illegal logging. The country has experienced a notable loss of forest cover, with a 13% decrease in tree cover from 2001 to 2023, resulting in the emission of approximately 133 million tonnes of CO₂ equivalent. The primary drivers of deforestation include agricultural expansion, illegal logging, urban development, and the conversion of forested areas into non-forest land uses. These activities not only reduce biodiversity but also disrupt the livelihoods of communities dependent on forest resources. In regions like the Chittagong Hill Tracts, deforestation has led to soil erosion, reduced water retention, and increased vulnerability to natural disasters. The Sundarbans, the world's largest mangrove forest located in Bangladesh, faces threats from deforestation, overfishing, and pollution. This ecosystem is crucial for carbon sequestration, coastal protection, and supporting diverse wildlife. The loss of mangrove forests exacerbates the impacts of climate change, including rising sea levels and increased frequency of extreme weather events. Recognizing the severity of deforestation, Bangladesh has committed to the Glasgow Leaders' Declaration on Forests and Land Use, pledging to end or reduce deforestation by 2030. However, achieving this goal requires concerted efforts in policy enforcement, community engagement, and sustainable land-use practices. Protecting and restoring forests is essential for maintaining biodiversity, mitigating climate change, and ensuring the well-being of future generations. Also, Public awareness and government action are crucial to prevent further deforestation and mitigate its impacts on the environment and the people of Bangladesh.

The Greenhouse Effect: A Growing Concern for Our Planet

The greenhouse effect is a natural process that warms the Earth's surface. It occurs when certain gases in the Earth's atmosphere, called greenhouse gases, trap heat from the sun. These gases—mainly carbon dioxide (CO₂), methane (CH₄), nitrous oxide (N₂O), and water vapor—allow sunlight to enter the atmosphere but prevent some of the heat from escaping back into space. This process keeps the Earth warm enough to support life, as it maintains a comfortable average temperature of about 59°F (15°C).

However, human activities, such as burning fossil fuels (like coal, oil, and natural gas) for energy, deforestation, and industrial processes, have increased the concentration of these greenhouse gases in the atmosphere. This enhanced greenhouse effect is causing global temperatures to rise at an alarming rate, leading to what we know as global warming. As more heat is trapped, the Earth's climate systems begin to change. The melting of polar ice caps and glaciers leads to rising sea levels, threatening coastal areas with flooding. Warmer temperatures also cause more extreme weather events, including heatwaves, hurricanes, and heavy rainfall. This shift in climate patterns can disrupt ecosystems, harm agriculture, and endanger water resources, affecting millions of people worldwide. The greenhouse effect is also linked to the acceleration of climate change, which has far-reaching consequences for our environment and future generations. To reduce the impact of the enhanced greenhouse effect, we must focus on reducing greenhouse gas emissions by shifting to renewable energy sources, improving energy efficiency, and adopting sustainable practices. Reducing deforestation and protecting natural carbon sinks, like forests and oceans, is also essential in controlling the levels of greenhouse gases in the atmosphere and mitigating the impact of climate change.

A Visit to a Palace of Historical Interest in Bangladesh

During my visit to the Ahsan Manzil, a historical palace in Dhaka, I was transported back in time to the era of the Nawabs of Bengal. Ahsan Manzil, often called the "Pink Palace" due to its striking pink-colored walls, is an iconic symbol of the grandeur and opulence of 19th-century Bengal. Originally built in the mid-1800s as the residence of the Nawab of Dhaka, it later served as the official residence of the Nawab family. The palace is located along the banks of the Buriganga River, offering a scenic and historical view of the surrounding area. Upon entering the palace, I was captivated by its architectural beauty, blending Mughal, European, and local styles. The spacious rooms, with their high ceilings, large windows, and intricate wooden work, showcase the lavish lifestyle of the Nawabs. The museum inside the palace is filled with antique furniture, portraits, and items from the Nawab era, providing a glimpse into the rich cultural heritage of Bangladesh.

I also learned about the historical significance of Ahsan Manzil during the British colonial period, where it became a hub for political and social gatherings. The palace played a key role in the Bengal Renaissance, a period of cultural and intellectual revival. The charm of the place was not just in its physical beauty but also in the stories it held within its walls about the history, struggles, and transformations of the region. A visit to Ahsan Manzil is a fascinating journey into the past, offering visitors a chance to experience the historical richness and architectural splendor of Bangladesh. The palace stands as a reminder of the nation's history, reflecting both its colonial past and its cultural resilience.

COVID-19: A Global Pandemic with Lasting Impacts

COVID-19, caused by the SARS-CoV-2 virus, emerged in late 2019 and rapidly became a global pandemic. It primarily spreads through respiratory droplets and affects individuals differently, with common symptoms including fever, cough, and fatigue. While most cases are mild, the virus can lead to severe illness and death, particularly among older adults and those with underlying health conditions. The pandemic has had profound effects on global health systems, economies, and daily life. Healthcare facilities worldwide faced unprecedented

challenges, with hospitals overwhelmed and medical supplies in short supply. Economically, the pandemic triggered a global recession, leading to widespread job losses, business closures, and disruptions in trade and supply chains. Governments implemented lockdowns and social distancing measures to curb the virus's spread, which, while necessary, also contributed to economic downturns. In response, the scientific community developed and deployed vaccines at an unprecedented pace, significantly reducing the severity and spread of the virus. However, challenges remain, including the emergence of new variants, such as Omicron, and the ongoing phenomenon of long COVID, where individuals experience prolonged symptoms. As of 2025, while many countries have made significant progress in managing the virus, the long-term effects of the pandemic continue to influence global health policies, economic strategies, and societal norms. The lessons learned from COVID-19 underscore the importance of preparedness, international cooperation, and resilience in the face of future public health challenges.

Pahela Baishakh: The Bengali New Year Celebration

Pahela Baishakh, celebrated on April 14th, marks the first day of the Bengali New Year and is one of the most vibrant and cherished festivals in Bangladesh. The occasion has deep cultural significance and is a time for renewal, reflection, and celebration. The tradition dates back to the Mughal era when Emperor Akbar introduced a new calendar system to align the harvest with the fiscal year, thus beginning the Bengali lunisolar calendar. On this day, people from all walks of life come together to celebrate the start of a new year with joy and enthusiasm. The day begins with a traditional breakfast of panta bhat (fermented rice), hilsa fish, and a variety of sweets like roshogolla and mishti doi (sweetened yogurt). The streets are filled with colorful processions, the most famous being the Mangal Shobhajatra in Dhaka, a grand parade featuring giant masks, colorful floats, and effigies representing cultural symbols. This procession, organized by the students of Dhaka University, showcases the rich cultural heritage of Bangladesh and has been recognized by UNESCO.

People dress in traditional attire, often in red and white, which symbolize purity and peace. Markets are filled with decorations, and fairs (mela) take place across the country. Pahela Baishakh transcends religious boundaries, uniting people from all walks of life in a celebration of cultural pride and national identity. It serves as a reminder of the shared heritage and collective aspirations of the Bengali people. The festival not only honors the past but also inspires hope and unity for the future, offering traditional handicrafts and street food. The celebration is not just limited to urban areas; even in rural regions, the spirit of Pahela Baishakh is observed with enthusiasm.

Price Hike

A price hike means an increase in the cost of goods and services, making things more expensive for people to buy. This happens for many reasons, such as inflation, high demand, or a shortage of products. When the price of daily necessities like food, clothes, fuel, and medicine goes up, it becomes difficult for people, especially those with low incomes, to afford their basic needs. Families may have to cut down on their expenses and buy only the most important things. A price hike affects everyone, from students to workers and business owners. For example, when

fuel prices go up, transportation costs also rise, making travel more expensive. This also increases the cost of goods because trucks and ships need fuel to transport items. Similarly, if farmers have to pay more for seeds and fertilizers, the price of vegetables and grains will go up. Even school supplies, like books and notebooks, can become more costly, making it harder for students to get the things they need for their studies. Businesses also face problems due to price hikes. If the cost of raw materials increases, companies may have to raise the prices of their products. Sometimes, they struggle to sell their goods because people cannot afford them, which affects the economy. Governments try to control price hikes by setting fair prices, providing subsidies, or taking other steps to help people. However, everyone can help by reducing waste, using resources wisely, and supporting local products. In conclusion, a price hike is a big challenge, but with smart decisions and careful planning, we can manage its effects and make life easier for everyone.